

Neurodiversity as Politics

Ari Ne’eman^{a, b, c} Elizabeth Pellicano^{d, e}

^aPhD Program in Health Policy, Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Cambridge, MA, USA;
^bHarvard Law School Project on Disability, Harvard University, Cambridge, MA, USA; ^cLurie Institute for
Disability Policy, Brandeis University, Waltham, MA, USA; ^dMacquarie School of Education, Macquarie
University, Sydney, NSW, Australia; ^eDepartment of Clinical, Educational and Health Psychology, University
College London, London, UK

Keywords

Advocacy · Autism · Disability · Movement · Neurodiversity

The debate around neurodiversity is itself diverse. As Dwyer (2022) puts it in his own contribution to this special issue of *Human Development*, there are multiple “neurodiversity approaches” deployed differently by different actors to different ends, even within the movement. This diversity presents some opportunities, allowing different groups to adapt the idea for their own purposes. Nonetheless, it can also lead to confusion, co-optation, acrimony, and other unintended consequences.

As such, in our commentary, we seek to situate the papers within the broader debate around neurodiversity, with the aim of highlighting key areas in which different voices within the neurodiversity movement hold divergent viewpoints. We also offer our own views as to how to resolve these conflicts, although our intent is to encourage debate and deliberate decision-making between these different “neurodiversity approaches” (the recognition of which represents a major contribution by Dwyer), not to insist that the movement’s future can only have one path. In highlighting these fissures, we hope to set the stage for a more robust dialogue on the future of neurodiversity in activism, academia, and beyond.

Origins

The neurodiversity movement first emerged in the 1990s as a response to the excesses of traditional autism advocacy. Though the term would come later, the movement’s origins date back to Sinclair’s (1993) seminal 1993 essay “Don’t Mourn for Us,” encouraging parents to shift their approach to their child’s autism away from cure and towards acceptance. Sinclair contended that parent-led autism groups encouraged “mourning for what never was” rather than “exploration of what is.” In so doing, Sinclair set the stage for a radical challenge to conventional autism discourse. “Don’t Mourn for Us” did not just represent a break from the dominant parent-centric autism narratives – it also broke from the limited role available to autistic persons in public discussion.

As Pripas-Kapit (2020) notes in one of the few academic explorations of neurodiversity’s founding text, Sinclair’s immediate predecessors took a very different approach, typically limiting themselves to first-person narrative rather than ethical or political critique. Autistic authors and public speakers like Temple Grandin spoke predominantly to non-autistic audiences, parents, and

<https://orcid.org/0000-0001-7687-1265>, <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-7246-8003>

Correspondence to:
Ari Ne’eman, aneeman@g.harvard.edu

Karger@karger.com
www.karger.com/hde



神经多样性作为政治

Ari Ne’eman^{a, b, c} Elizabeth Pellicano^{d, e}

^a哈佛文理研究生院健康政策博士项目，美国马萨诸塞州剑桥；^b哈佛法学院残障项目，哈佛大学，美国马萨诸塞州剑桥；^cLurie残障政策研究所，布兰代斯大学，美国马萨诸塞州沃尔瑟姆；^d麦考瑞教育学院，麦考瑞大学，澳大利亚新南威尔士州悉尼；^e临床、教育与健康心理学系，伦敦大学学院，英国伦敦

关键词

Advocacy · Autism · Disability · Movement · Neurodiversity

围绕神经多样性的讨论本身就具有多样性。正如 Dwyer（2022）在他为这期《人类发展》特刊撰写的文章中所言，即便在该运动内部，也存在多种由不同行动者为实现不同目的而采取的不同“神经多样性路径”。这种多样性带来了一些机遇，使得不同群体能够根据自身需求调整这一理念。然而，它也可能导致困惑、概念被挪用、激烈争执以及其他非预期的后果。

因此，在我们的评论中，我们试图将这些论文置于围绕神经多样性的更广泛辩论中，旨在突显神经多样性运动内部不同声音持有分歧观点的关键领域。我们也提出了自己关于如何解决这些冲突的看法，尽管我们的意图是鼓励这些不同的“神经多样性路径”（承认这些路径是Dwyer的一项主要贡献）之间进行辩论和审慎决策，而非坚持认为该运动的未来只能有一条道路。通过突显这些分歧，我们希望能在行动主义、学术界及其他领域就神经多样性的未来展开更坚实的对话奠定基础。

起源

神经多样性运动最初兴起于20世纪90年代，是对传统孤独谱系倡导中过激行为的回应。尽管这个术语出现较晚，但该运动的起源可追溯至Sinclair（1993）1993年的开创性文章《不要为我们哀悼》，该文鼓励父母将对孩子孤独谱系的态度从寻求治愈转向接纳。Sinclair认为，家长主导的孤独谱系团体鼓励的是“为从未存在的事物哀悼”，而非“探索当下的现实”。通过此举，Sinclair为挑战传统的孤独谱系话语奠定了激进的基础。《不要为我们哀悼》不仅代表了对当时占主导地位的、以家长为中心的孤独谱系叙事的突破——它也打破了孤独谱系群体在公共讨论中所能扮演的有限角色。

正如 Pripas-Kapit（2020）在对神经多样性奠基文本为数不多的学术探讨中指出的那样，Sinclair 的直接先驱们采取了截然不同的方法，通常局限于第一人称叙述，而非伦理或政治批判。像 Temple Grandin 这样的孤独谱系作者和公众演讲者，主要面向非孤独谱系听众、父母以及

<https://orcid.org/0000-0001-7687-1265>, <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-7246-8003>

通讯作者：Ari Ne’eman,
aneeman@g.harvard.edu

Karger@karger.com
www.karger.com/hde



Downloaded from <http://karger.com/hde/article-pdf/66/2/149/3750903/000524277.pdf> by guest on 08 January 2026

professionals. Though Sinclair engaged in some similar public speaking, “Don’t Mourn for Us” also represented something new: a rebuke of parent autism spaces from an autistic adult, speaking on behalf of a broader community. When Sinclair wrote that xe invited parents “to look at our autism, and look at your grief, from our perspective,” it was the articulation of a larger critique, emerging out of an incipient autistic adult community distinct from the more established and powerful autism parent one. As other autistic persons responded to the essay and flocked to autistic cultural spaces, this community grew and evolved.

The early autistic community came together very informally. Gatherings took place predominantly on the sidelines of parent conferences and in online listservs, both places where autistic adults had begun to seek out others like them (Dekker, 1999; Sinclair, 2005, 2010). Autism was still perceived as a condition that impacted children – little thought went into the possibility that autistic persons eventually grew up. Autism and agency were seen as so incompatible with each other that, in the introduction to Grandin’s 1986 biography *Emergence: Labeled Autistic*, prominent autism researcher Bernie Rimland described Grandin as “a recovered autistic individual” (Grandin & Scariano, 1986).

The founding of Autism Network International (ANI), the first autistic-run organization, offered an infrastructure for autistic culture. Under Sinclair’s leadership, ANI would organize Autreat, an annual conference run by and for autistic adults, for many years (see also its later UK counterpart, Autscope; Buckle, 2020). For autistic attendees, Autreat was often the first exposure to “autistic space” – an environment in which autistic persons were the norm. Not only did Autreat spawn many innovations in accessibility for autistic people, including its Color Communications Badge system, it also encouraged autistic persons who attended to feel comfortable behaving and interacting in the manner most natural to them. As one autistic attendee put it, “I feel as if I’m home, among my own people, for the first time. I never knew what this was until now” (Sinclair, 2005). The sudden (and temporary) experience of connection prompted many autistic attendees to compare life in the predominantly non-autistic world to that of a diaspora community (Sinclair, 2005, 2010). Non-autistic attendees often found their brief experience in majority-autistic space impactful too. As Sinclair (2005) put it: “One NT [neurotypical] attendee described feeling unsure of how to behave and how to relate to people, confused about how to interpret other people’s behavior, and anxious that he might offend people with-

out realizing it....” In other words, he was able to experience at Autreat some of the same social confusion and discomfort that autistic people frequently experience in NT society. (Freedom from Pressures section)

Such experiences prompted empathy, encouraging non-autistic persons to look at autistic culture and ways of interaction as more legitimate than they might otherwise have considered them.

Though the conference never had more than one hundred attendees in any given year, many who came to it would go on to play leading roles as the movement grew. One of us (A.N.) was inspired to co-found the Autistic Self Advocacy Network (ASAN), now the USA’s leading autistic-run advocacy group, from such experiences. Many other longstanding autistic community leaders had Autreat’s immersive communal autistic experience as their starting point. Over time, ANI and Autreat would serve as a seed for a growing and powerful social movement, as autistic people expressed growing frustration with the cure- and tragedy-oriented narratives promoted by groups like Autism Speaks and others (Heilker & Yergeau, 2011; Kras, 2010). What began on the fringe would soon be pushed into the mainstream, led by a growing cohort of autistic-run advocacy groups working to advance neurodiversity at the local, national, and international level.

This history is important to bear in mind as neurodiversity attracts growing interest. Today, the term neurodiversity yields thousands of results on Google Scholar. A growing number of universities boast neurodiversity initiatives, typically focused on some combination of research into neurological disability and supporting greater access to higher education. Major international corporations like Ernst & Young and Microsoft boast “neurodiversity hiring programs” that recruit autistic jobseekers as well as others with neurological disabilities (Ernst & Young, n.d.; Microsoft, n.d.). In December 2020, the US federal government welcomed the first participants in the Neurodiverse Federal Workforce pilot program (Thomas, 2021). Neurodiversity is still far from dominant, even in the context of autism (Leadbitter et al., 2021; Pellicano & den Houting, 2022), but it has firmly entered the cultural mainstream, with the concept referred to frequently by parents and professionals alongside the autistic persons who first initiated it. Furthermore, autistic people themselves have built infrastructure in the form of advocacy groups, cultural convenings, and even businesses oriented around the movement’s ideas and larger philosophy.

This growth is in many ways beneficial, but it also presents challenges. Neurodiversity emerged in a relatively

experts. Though Sinclair also engaged in some similar public speaking, “Don’t Mourn for Us” also represented something new: a rebuke of parent autism spaces from an autistic adult, speaking on behalf of a broader community. When Sinclair wrote that xe invited parents “to look at our autism, and look at your grief, from our perspective,” it was the articulation of a larger critique, emerging out of an incipient autistic adult community distinct from the more established and powerful autism parent one. As other autistic persons responded to the essay and flocked to autistic cultural spaces, this community grew and evolved.

The early autistic community came together very informally. Gatherings took place predominantly on the sidelines of parent conferences and in online listservs, both places where autistic adults had begun to seek out others like them (Dekker, 1999; Sinclair, 2005, 2010). Autism was still perceived as a condition that impacted children – little thought went into the possibility that autistic persons eventually grew up. Autism and agency were seen as so incompatible with each other that, in the introduction to Grandin’s 1986 biography *Emergence: Labeled Autistic*, prominent autism researcher Bernie Rimland described Grandin as “a recovered autistic individual” (Grandin & Scariano, 1986).

The founding of Autism Network International (ANI), the first autistic-run organization, offered an infrastructure for autistic culture. Under Sinclair’s leadership, ANI would organize Autreat, an annual conference run by and for autistic adults, for many years (see also its later UK counterpart, Autscope; Buckle, 2020). For autistic attendees, Autreat was often the first exposure to “autistic space” – an environment in which autistic persons were the norm. Not only did Autreat spawn many innovations in accessibility for autistic people, including its Color Communications Badge system, it also encouraged autistic persons who attended to feel comfortable behaving and interacting in the manner most natural to them. As one autistic attendee put it, “I feel as if I’m home, among my own people, for the first time. I never knew what this was until now” (Sinclair, 2005). The sudden (and temporary) experience of connection prompted many autistic attendees to compare life in the predominantly non-autistic world to that of a diaspora community (Sinclair, 2005, 2010). Non-autistic attendees often found their brief experience in majority-autistic space impactful too. As Sinclair (2005) put it: “One NT [neurotypical] attendee described feeling unsure of how to behave and how to relate to people, confused about how to interpret other people’s behavior, and anxious that he might offend people with-

out realizing it....” In other words, he was able to experience at Autreat some of the same social confusion and discomfort that autistic people frequently experience in NT society. (Freedom from Pressures section)

Such experiences prompted empathy, encouraging non-autistic persons to look at autistic culture and ways of interaction as more legitimate than they might otherwise have considered them.

Though the conference never had more than one hundred attendees in any given year, many who came to it would go on to play leading roles as the movement grew. One of us (A.N.) was inspired to co-found the Autistic Self Advocacy Network (ASAN), now the USA’s leading autistic-run advocacy group, from such experiences. Many other longstanding autistic community leaders had Autreat’s immersive communal autistic experience as their starting point. Over time, ANI and Autreat would serve as a seed for a growing and powerful social movement, as autistic people expressed growing frustration with the cure- and tragedy-oriented narratives promoted by groups like Autism Speaks and others (Heilker & Yergeau, 2011; Kras, 2010). What began on the fringe would soon be pushed into the mainstream, led by a growing cohort of autistic-run advocacy groups working to advance neurodiversity at the local, national, and international level.

This history is important to bear in mind as neurodiversity attracts growing interest. Today, the term neurodiversity yields thousands of results on Google Scholar. A growing number of universities boast neurodiversity initiatives, typically focused on some combination of research into neurological disability and supporting greater access to higher education. Major international corporations like Ernst & Young and Microsoft boast “neurodiversity hiring programs” that recruit autistic jobseekers as well as others with neurological disabilities (Ernst & Young, n.d.; Microsoft, n.d.). In December 2020, the US federal government welcomed the first participants in the Neurodiverse Federal Workforce pilot program (Thomas, 2021). Neurodiversity is still far from dominant, even in the context of autism (Leadbitter et al., 2021; Pellicano & den Houting, 2022), but it has firmly entered the cultural mainstream, with the concept referred to frequently by parents and professionals alongside the autistic persons who first initiated it. Furthermore, autistic people themselves have built infrastructure in the form of advocacy groups, cultural convenings, and even businesses oriented around the movement’s ideas and larger philosophy.

This growth is in many ways beneficial, but it also presents challenges. Neurodiversity emerged in a relatively

tight-knit community without an extensive written record or much engagement with academia. As we see it, over time, as the specific terminology of the original community has been incorporated into the work of those with more social, cultural, and economic capital (both inside and outside the autistic community), the movement’s terminology has been deployed to new purposes.

Often, terms that meant one thing to the activists that spawned them have been used very differently by academics and business leaders. Ambiguity about the “true” meaning of neurodiversity has at times meant that different voices within the movement have sought to confidently present their own views as the only authentic representation. This ambiguity can also prompt newcomers to adopt and even insist upon positions that would have been alien to or extreme to those who cultivated neurodiversity’s roots (e.g., rejection of autism as a disability or an espousal of unspecified autistic superpowers; see den Houting, 2019). Uncertainty over what the movement stands for has at times prompted observers to attack neurodiversity proponents for views they by and large do not hold. Much of the present-day debate over neurodiversity is akin to a game of telephone, with many attacking or praising ideas or usages that are very different from what their interlocuters intend. Inevitable as this may be, discussions of neurodiversity would benefit from awareness of these tensions and the challenges they present.

Neurodiversity as a Descriptive Term or Ideology?

One of the more basic questions that emerges in considering neurodiversity is one of terminology: is neurodiversity the name of a social movement, a simple biological reality (reflecting the existence of multiple kinds of brains), or both? As Chapman (2020) notes, some have defined the movement exclusively in political terms while others have sought to frame neurodiversity as a descriptive fact. Walker (2014) argues that neurodiversity refers to “the diversity of human minds, the infinite variation in neurocognitive functioning within our species... Neurodiversity is a biological fact. It’s not a perspective, an approach, a belief, a political position, or a paradigm.” Walker goes on to argue that the political implications of neurodiversity should be referred to as the “neurodiversity paradigm,” distinguishing the normative implications from the biological fact.

Though framed as the authoritative pronouncement of the movement, this perspective is far from the only point of view in autistic activist circles. Many autistic ac-

tivists have framed neurodiversity as an explicitly political position in both communications to the broader community and the academic literature, referring to neurodiversity as “acceptance for neurological differences and disabilities” (Durbin-Westby, 2012) or explicitly framing it as an “alternative perspective... in contrast to the deficit model” (Robertson, 2010) rather than a simple biological reality. This tension is present even within this issue – for example, contrast Zajic and Brown’s (2022) reference to “neurodiversity proponents” and “neurodiversity advocates” (consistent with the use of the term to describe an ideology) with Radulski’s (2022) reference to neurodiversity as a “field” (consistent with the descriptive tradition of the term). In contrast to Walker, we believe that the use of the word neurodiversity, without further qualifiers, has a long history of being used in autistic activist communities to describe biology and ideology, with some believing the term refers only to one of these options and others applying it to both. Recognizing that others may adopt different conventions, in this article we use the term exclusively to describe the ideology for reasons we now articulate.

In principle, the distinction is mere semantics. But in practice, the existence of neurodiversity as a purely descriptive concept removes from the term its most important implications. For better or worse, if neurodiversity refers simply to the fact of neurological variation, there is no inherent reason for the term not to be used in association with efforts to cure or prevent autism or other similar neurological disabilities. Similarly, this descriptive neurodiversity is perfectly consistent with advertising analogizing autism or other similar conditions as akin to death or kidnapping, precisely the type of messaging the movement sought to combat in its early years (Heilker & Yergeau, 2011; Kras, 2010; Rottier & Gernsbacher, 2020). If the term neurodiversity has no normative implications, there is no basis to object to the way it is deployed in such contexts.

Efforts to draw a finely grained distinction between “neurodiversity” and the “neurodiversity paradigm” are also likely too subtle for most activist and advocacy contexts, particularly given the imperative for autistic and other disabled activists to keep their language accessible to a broad audience, including persons with cognitive impairments and without access to higher education. If the “center of gravity” for the neurodiversity movement is to stay in the realm of activism rather than in academia, these issues must be considered.

These questions also raise another important concern: the appropriateness of the increasingly common use of

紧密的社群，当时缺乏详尽的书面记录，也较少与学术界互动。在我们看来，随着时间的推移，原社群特有的术语已被那些拥有更多社会、文化和经济资本的人（无论其身处孤独谱系社群内外）纳入其工作中，这场运动的术语已被用于新的目的。

通常，那些对催生它们的活动家而言具有特定含义的术语，被学术界和商界领袖以截然不同的方式使用。关于神经多样性“真实”含义的模糊性，有时意味着运动内部的不同声音都试图自信地将其个人观点呈现为唯一真实的代表。这种模糊性也可能促使新来者采纳、甚至坚持那些对于培育神经多样性根基的人们而言是陌生或极端的立场（例如，拒绝将孤独谱系视为一种残疾，或拥护未加说明的孤独谱系超能力；参见 den Houting, 2019）。对于该运动所代表理念的不确定性，有时会促使观察者攻击神经多样性的支持者，指责他们持有其大体上并不认同的观点。当下许多关于神经多样性的辩论，类似于一场传话游戏，许多人攻击或赞扬的观点或用法，与其对话者本意相去甚远。尽管这可能不可避免，但对神经多样性的讨论若能意识到这些张力及其带来的挑战，将大有裨益。

神经多样性是描述性术语还是意识形态？

在思考神经多样性时，一个更基本的问题涉及术语：神经多样性是一个社会运动的名称，是一种简单的生物现实（反映了多种大脑类型的存在），还是两者兼而有之？正如 Chapman (2020) 所指出的，有些人完全从政治角度定义这一运动，而另一些人则试图将神经多样性框定作为一种描述性事实。Walker (2014) 认为，神经多样性指的是“人类思维的多样性，即我们物种内部神经认知功能的无限变异……神经多样性是一个生物学事实。它不是一种观点、一种方法、一种信念、一种政治立场或一种范式。” Walker 进一步主张，神经多样性的政治含义应被称为“神经多样性范式”，从而将规范性含义与生物学事实区分开来。

尽管这一观点被塑造成该运动的权威宣言，但在孤独谱系活动家圈子里，它远非唯一的观点。许多孤独谱系活-

动家将神经多样性明确界定为一种政治立场，无论是在与更广泛社区的沟通中，还是在学术文献里，都将神经多样性称为“对神经学差异和残疾的接纳”（Durbin-Westby, 2012），或明确将其描述为“一种替代视角……与缺陷模型相对”（Robertson, 2010），而非简单的生物学现实。这种张力在本期内容中亦有体现——例如，对比 Zajic 和 Brown (2022) 提及的“神经多样性支持者”和“神经多样性倡导者”（与将该术语用于描述一种意识形态的用法一致）与 Radulski (2022) 将神经多样性称为一个“领域”的提法（与该术语的描述性传统一致）。与 Walker 的观点不同，我们认为，“神经多样性”一词不加限定地使用，在孤独谱系活动家社区中有着悠久的历史，既用来描述生物学事实，也用来描述意识形态；有些人认为该术语仅指其中一种含义，而另一些人则将其应用于两者。我们认识到他人可能采用不同的惯例，在本文中，出于我们要阐述的原因，我们使用该术语专指这种意识形态。

原则上，这种区分仅仅是语义上的。但在实践中，将神经多样性作为一个纯粹描述性概念的存在，却剥离了这个术语最重要的内涵。无论如何，如果神经多样性仅仅指神经学上存在差异这一事实，那么该术语就没有内在理由不能与旨在治愈或预防孤独谱系或其他类似神经障碍的努力相关联。同样，这种描述性的神经多样性与那些将孤独谱系或其他类似状况类比为死亡或绑架的广告宣传完全相容，而这正是该运动早期试图对抗的信息类型（Heilker & Yergeau, 2011; Kras, 2010; Rottier & Gernsbacher, 2020）。如果神经多样性这一术语没有规范性内涵，就没有理由反对它在这些语境中的使用方式。

试图在“神经多样性”与“神经多样性范式”之间做出精细区分的努力，对于大多数行动主义和倡导语境而言也可能过于微妙，特别是考虑到孤独谱系人士及其他残障活动者必须确保其语言能为广大受众所理解，包括有认知障碍和未接受高等教育的人群。如果神经多样性运动的“重心”要保持在行动主义领域而非学术界，就必须考虑这些问题。

这些问题也引出了另一个重要的关切点：越来越普遍地使用

terms like “neurodivergent” or “neurodiverse,” both of which are often used to describe those for whom the concept of neurodiversity applies, though proponents of the former argue the latter is grammatically nonsensical. These terms emerged in large part out of a desire to clarify that the term neurodiversity in either its descriptive or ideological terms applies outside of autism (Asasumasu, 2016; Chapman, 2021). But their usage presents a new problem: neurodiversity activists have long emphasized the connection between their movement and the broader disability community, explicitly rejecting claims that the movement “views autism as a difference but not a disability” (Bailin, 2019; den Houting, 2019; Ne’eman & Bascom, 2020). We agree with this interpretation of the movement’s political commitments.

However, the usage of neurodiversity as a descriptive term seems to imply a fear of the term disability. Why not simply refer to this population as the neurologically or (where appropriate) developmentally disabled? What purpose does the additional descriptive term have, if autistic people and other “neurodivergent” persons are definitionally disabled as well? Returning to the idea that a movement that centers activists (rather than solely academics) and that seeks to include persons with cognitive disabilities must be attentive to the most likely possible interpretation of its terminology, we wonder if the growing usage of terms like “neurodivergent” has confused matters.

After all, the commonsense interpretation of the creation of a special word to refer to neurological disability is that those who engage in such an act of creation find the latter term unacceptable in some way. While the accusation that neurodiversity proponents do not see autism as a disability is often made in bad faith, the increasing prominence of the descriptive use of the term neurodiversity makes this a more understandable error. It may even represent an accurate description of what motivates some persons to adopt the language of neurodiversity, even if this view is not prominent among movement leaders or organizations.

Sinclair and other early autistic activists were heavily influenced by other parts of the disability community. Autistic culture borrowed significantly from Deaf culture – for example, attendees at Autreat substituted traditional applause for “flapplause,” the rapid flapping of one’s hands instead of clapping them together. This has much in common with “deafapplause,” which typically involves hand waving (Solvang & Haualand, 2014). Similarly, much of the ideology and terminology of the neurodiversity movement borrows from the independent living

movement and the developmental disability self-advocacy movement, both of which emphasize the same themes of self-help and willingness to push back against professional and family member domination in the political sphere.

This disconnect from the larger disability context in which neurodiversity was born is a grave error. Neurodiversity proponents would do well to avoid “reinventing the wheel” in a way that might imply a rejection of the broader disability rights movement. As we shall shortly discuss, there are areas in which neurodiversity ideals add concepts that build upon and are (at the moment) distinct from broader disability rights ideologies. However, when describing concepts for which terminology exists in the larger disability realm, it may make more sense to rely on them.

For example, Radulski’s (2022) contribution offers an important exploration of neurodiversity activism against the demand that autistic people mask autistic traits, synthesizing the literature on the harmful impacts of “camouflaging” in autism with important concepts from literary, feminist, and disability theory. In so doing, Radulski makes use of terms like “neuroarchy” and “neurominority” to describe the experiences autistic people face living as social minorities in a majority-neurotypical world. While we agree that Radulski’s invoking of the concept of “neurotypical privilege” represents an important application of the idea of privilege to the world of autism, we wonder about the wisdom of terms like “neurominority,” which introduce new and somewhat exceptionalist language to describe concepts with long histories in broader disability activism. Where an idea is unique to the neurodiversity context, it may require new terminology. But where it does not, neurodiversity activists may benefit from looking for more accessible language that connects to the movements’ roots in the larger world of disability.

Defining the Boundaries of the Movement

Alongside the question of what the word neurodiversity means is the even more crucial question of who it applies to. Though neurodiversity has its origins in the world of autism, it has important implications outside of it as well (Bertilsdotter Rosqvist et al., 2020; Gillespie-Lynch et al., 2020). As Botha and Gillespie-Lynch (2022) note, in various contexts, conditions like ADHD, dyslexia, bipolar disorder, schizophrenia, intellectual disability, and many others have been asserted to fall under the neurodiversity umbrella. At times these claims have been

诸如“神经殊异”或“神经多元”这类术语是否恰当，这两个术语常被用来描述神经多样性概念所适用的人群，尽管前者的支持者认为后者在语法上毫无意义。这些术语的出现，很大程度上源于一种澄清的愿望：即神经多样性这一术语，无论是其描述性还是意识形态层面的含义，都适用于孤独谱系之外的情形（Asasumasu, 2016; Chapman, 2021）。但它们的用法带来了一个新问题：神经多样性活动家长期以来一直强调他们的运动与更广泛的残障社群之间的联系，并明确拒绝那种认为该运动“将孤独谱系视为一种差异而非残障”的说法（Bailin, 2019; den Houting, 2019; Ne’eman & Bascom, 2020）。我们赞同对这场运动政治承诺的这种解读。

然而，将神经多样性用作描述性术语，似乎暗示了对“残障”一词的恐惧。为什么不直接称这一群体为神经系统障碍者，或（在适当情况下）发展性残障者呢？既然自闭症人士和其他“神经殊异”者在定义上也属于残障群体，那么增加一个描述性术语有何目的？回到这样一个观点：一个以活动家（而非仅学者）为核心、并力求包容认知残障人士的运动，必须关注其术语最可能被如何解读。我们不禁怀疑，“神经殊异”等术语日益广泛的使用是否反而混淆了问题。

毕竟，从常识角度解读，专门创造一个词来指代神经系统障碍，意味着创造者认为后一个术语在某种程度上不可接受。尽管指责神经多样性支持者不将自闭症视为残障的说法常出于恶意，但“神经多样性”一词在描述性使用上日益突出，使得这种误解更易理解。它甚至可能准确地描述了促使某些人采用神经多样性语言的部分动机，即便这种观点在运动领袖或组织中并不占主导地位。

Sinclair和其他早期孤独谱系活动者深受残障社群其他部分的影响。孤独谱系文化大量借鉴了聋人文化——例如，Autreat的参与者用传统的鼓掌方式被“拍翅鼓掌”所取代，即快速挥动手掌而非双手拍击。这与“聋人鼓掌”有很多共同之处，后者通常涉及挥手动作（Solvang & Haualand, 2014）。同样，神经多样性运动的许多意识形态和术语也借鉴了独立生活

运动以及发展性障碍自我倡导运动，两者都强调自助和愿意在政治领域抵制专业人士及家庭成员支配的相同主题。

这种与孕育神经多样性的更广泛残障背景的脱节，是一个严重的错误。神经多样性的支持者最好避免“重新发明轮子”，以免其方式可能暗示对更广泛的残障权利运动的排斥。正如我们即将讨论的，在某些领域，神经多样性的理念确实增加了一些概念，这些概念建立在更广泛的残障权利意识形态之上，并且（目前）与之不同。然而，在描述那些在更广泛的残障领域中已有术语的概念时，依赖这些现有术语可能更为明智。

例如，Radulski（2022）的贡献对神经多样性行动主义进行了一次重要的探讨，旨在反对要求孤独谱系群体掩饰其孤独谱系特征，将关于“伪装”在孤独谱系中有害影响的文献，与文学、女权主义和残障理论中的重要概念相结合。在此过程中，Radulski使用了诸如“神经支配”和“神经少数群体”等术语来描述孤独谱系群体在一个神经典型占多数的世界中作为社会少数群体所面临的经历。虽然我们同意Radulski引入“神经典型特权”的概念是将特权观念应用于孤独谱系世界的重要应用，但我们质疑诸如“神经少数群体”这类术语的明智性，它们引入了新的、某种程度上带有例外论色彩的语言来描述在更广泛的残障行动主义中已有悠久历史的概念。当一个理念是神经多样性语境所独有的时，它可能需要新的术语。但在并非如此的情况下，神经多样性活动家或许可以从寻找更易理解的语言中受益，这种语言应能连接到运动在更广阔残障世界中的根源。

界定运动的边界

关于“神经多样性”一词含义的讨论，伴随着一个更为关键的问题：它适用于哪些人。尽管神经多样性起源于孤独谱系领域，但它在其他方面也具有重要影响（Bertilsdotter Rosqvist等人，2020; Gillespie-Lynch等人，2020）。正如Botha和Gillespie-Lynch（2022）所指出的，在不同语境下，诸如注意缺陷多动障碍、阅读障碍、双相情感障碍、精神分裂症、智力障碍等许多其他状况，都被主张应纳入神经多样性的范畴。有时这些主张是由

Downloaded from <http://karger.com/develop/article-pdf/66/2/149/3750903/000524277.pdf> by guest on 08 January 2026

made by persons with those conditions, at times by other neurodiversity activists seeking to frame the movement as maximally inclusive.

Insofar as neurodiversity has exclusively descriptive implications, scope is not a difficult question. But if the word neurodiversity has any ideological implications whatsoever, this becomes a very challenging area for debate, dependent entirely on what the scope of the neurodiversity ideology may be.

Some have framed neurodiversity’s ideological commitments as simply the application of the disability rights movement in the realm of mental disability. Under this definition, neurodiversity’s normative implications are the same as those of the broader disability rights movement and thus relate in large part to questions of accessibility and equality of opportunity. From this standpoint, taking the broadest possible definition of neurodiversity’s “scope” is not only appropriate – it is a moral necessity. After all, all persons with disabilities deserve the protections of non-discrimination and reasonable accommodation, among others, guaranteed by many national disability rights laws and the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities.

However, others have framed the neurodiversity movement as referring specifically to the rejection of the demand for typical appearance, cognition, or behavior – that is, the movement’s rejection of the goals of prevention and cure. While still rooted in disability rights, this definition of neurodiversity layers on top of it, representing a supplementary ideology with a new additional contribution. Under this definition, defining the boundaries of the neurodiversity movement becomes much trickier. While there are many diagnoses in which persons with the relevant disabilities reject the goal of suppression of symptoms, this is not universally the case. For example, while autistic repetitive behaviors are generally a source of pleasure or self-regulation, in the context of obsessive-compulsive disorder they are more frequently a source of distress (Jiujias et al., 2017; King, 2019; Ne’eman et al., 2020). Insofar as inclusion within the scope of neurodiversity activism implies a rejection of efforts to target, for intervention, traits associated with a given disability, some degree of selectivity is more appropriate.

While both ways of defining neurodiversity as an ideology are defensible, the latter is the more compelling. By making neurodiversity simply the application of disability rights in the realm of mental disability, activists gain a pithy slogan but lose the ability to refer specifically to the movement’s most important innovation: rejection of the idea that research and service provision should target pre-

vention, cure, or recovery towards normalcy. While this idea has some traction in other disability contexts, it is generally not as broadly applied – for example, while many physical disability activists argue against selective abortion and pre-implantation genetic diagnosis to remove persons with their disabilities from the gene pool (e.g., Asch & Barlevy, 2012), this critique usually does not extend to interventions aimed at already existing persons. It may be that a common “theory of everything” may be developed that allows the neurodiversity’s rejection of cure to be integrated seamlessly into all mental and non-mental disabilities (we discuss one possibility below), but until such an idea is articulated and accepted, we believe it important to retain language to explain neurodiversity’s unique contribution. Thus, defining neurodiversity through this second, more narrow approach is more appealing (for now).

Implicitly adopting this definition, Dwyer (2022) discusses several important considerations for how to define “the scope of neurodiversity approaches.” He notes and rejects arguments for defining neurodiversity to include those conditions that emerge “naturally,” that are associated with contributions to society, that are congenital (as opposed to acquired), and that prompt self-identification with the movement’s rejection of cure. This last comes closest to an acceptable criterion, but Dwyer justifiably rejects it for failing to account for circumstances like anorexia, where persons with a diagnosis may dangerously seek to reject efforts to ameliorate symptoms. We agree with this and add a further critique of relying solely on individual self-identification: the need for policymakers and researchers to have guidance from a community at large. While service-delivery may be approached on a largely individualized basis, the allocation of research funding and many other areas of public policy often require engaging with groups as broader communities, despite their considerable heterogeneity.

Another more radical critique of the broadest possible application of neurodiversity may be found in the existence of other challenges to traditional psychiatric practice. For example, the mental health consumer/psychiatric survivor movement has long emphasized the value of “recovery” from mental illness diagnoses as a form of resistance to psychiatrists who reject the possibility of it. Far from representing a simple clinical goal, recovery in this context has radical implications, often used as the basis to push back against involuntary treatment, institutionalization, and the long-term denial of legal capacity (Morrison, 2013). In contrast, in the autism context “recovery” is a term used by parents and providers seeking to force

患有这些状况的人士提出的，有时则是由其他神经多样性活动家提出的，他们试图将这场运动构建为尽可能包容的。

只要神经多样性仅具有描述性含义，其范围就不是一个难题。但如果‘神经多样性’这个词具有任何意识形态层面的含义，这就成为一个极具挑战性的辩论领域，完全取决于神经多样性意识形态的范围可能是什么。

一些人将神经多样性的意识形态承诺简单地框定为残障权利运动在精神残障领域的应用。根据这一定义，神经多样性的规范性含义与更广泛的残障权利运动相同，因此在很大程度上涉及无障碍环境和机会平等的问题。从这个角度看，对神经多样性的‘范围’采取尽可能宽泛的定义不仅是恰当的——更是一种道德必需。毕竟，所有残障人士都应享有非歧视和合理便利等保障，这些权利已得到许多国家残障权利法律以及联合国《残疾人权利公约》的保证。

然而，也有人将神经多样性运动具体定义为对要求具备典型外貌、认知或行为的拒绝——即该运动对预防和治愈目标的拒绝。虽然这一定义仍植根于残障权利，但它在基础上增加了一层含义，代表了一种具有新附加贡献的补充性意识形态。根据这一定义，界定神经多样性运动的边界变得棘手得多。虽然存在许多诊断，其中相关残障人士拒绝以抑制症状为目标，但这并非普遍情况。例如，虽然孤独谱系的重复行为通常是愉悦或自我调节的来源，但在强迫症的背景下，它们更常是痛苦的来源（Jiujias等，2017；King，2019；Ne’eman等，2020）。只要纳入神经多样性行动主义的范畴意味着拒绝针对与特定残障相关的特质进行干预，那么某种程度的选择性就更为合适。

尽管将神经多样性定义为一种意识形态的两种方式都站得住脚，但后者更具说服力。通过将神经多样性简单地视为残疾权利在精神残障领域的应用，活动人士获得了一个精炼的口号，却失去了特指该运动最重要创新的能力：即拒绝研究和服务提供应以

预防、治愈或康复至常态为目标。尽管这一理念在其他残疾语境中也有一定影响力，但通常并未被广泛运用——例如，尽管许多肢体残疾活动人士反对通过选择性堕胎和植入前遗传学诊断来将带有其残疾的人从基因库中移除（如Asch与Barlevy，2012年），但这种批评通常并不延伸至针对已存在个体的干预措施。或许未来会发展出一种通用的“万物理论”，使神经多样性对治愈的拒斥能够无缝融入所有精神与非精神残障中（我们将在下文讨论一种可能性），但在此类理念被阐明和接受之前，我们认为保留解释神经多样性独特贡献的语言至关重要。因此，目前来看，通过这第二种更狭义的方式来定义神经多样性更具吸引力。

Dwyer (2022) 在隐含地采纳这一定义的同时，讨论了如何界定“神经多样性路径的范围”的几个重要考量。他指出并驳斥了将神经多样性定义为包含那些“自然”出现的、与社会贡献相关的、先天性的（而非后天获得的）状况的论点，以及那些促使个体认同该运动拒绝治愈理念的状况。最后一点最接近一个可接受的标准，但Dwyer有理由地拒绝了它，因为它未能考虑到像厌食症这样的情况——被诊断者可能危险地拒绝任何改善症状的努力。我们同意这一点，并进一步批评了仅依赖个体自我认同的做法：政策制定者和研究者需要来自更广泛社区的指导。虽然服务提供可以在很大程度上以个体化为基础，但研究资金的分配以及公共政策的许多其他领域，通常需要与作为更广泛群体的社群进行接触，尽管它们内部存在显著的异质性。

对于神经多样性最广泛可能应用的另一种更为激进的批评，可能存在于其他对传统精神病学实践的挑战中。例如，心理健康服务使用者/精神病学幸存者运动长期以来一直强调从精神疾病诊断中“康复”的价值，以此作为对那些否认康复可能性的精神病学家们的抵抗。在这种语境下，康复远非代表一个简单的临床目标，而是具有激进的意涵，常被用作抵制非自愿治疗、机构化以及长期剥夺法律行为能力的依据（Morrison, 2013）。相比之下，在孤独谱系语境中，“康复”一词被寻求迫使

autistic persons into looking and acting normal (see Fein et al., 2013). Associated with the behaviorist approach to autism, neurodiversity activists have long seen the desire to “recover” autistic persons as a tool of abusive forms of intervention (Autistic Self Advocacy Network, 2013; Ne’eman, 2021; Padawar, 2014). In fact, autistic activists actively lobbied against the inclusion of “recovery criteria” in the DSM-5 definition of autism (Kapp & Ne’eman, 2020).

In seeking maximum inclusion, there is a risk that neurodiversity activists may inadvertently practice a sort of ideological imperialism: insisting on importing a specific critique and worldview into communities with their own, pre-existing and incompatible ideological commitments. Of course, there are many persons with mental illness who do seek to apply neurodiversity to their own conditions (Graby, 2015; Hart, 2020). Such differences of opinion exist in every community – insofar as they can be resolved, they are best done so through internal debate and disputation within the boundaries of that community itself, rather than the imposition of an outside ideology by well-meaning allies. As such, we suggest a consideration of politics in addition to those ethical factors articulated in Dwyer’s discussion of the boundaries of neurodiversity: the neurodiversity movement should seek to make itself relevant in those disability communities where a sufficient internal constituency exists for the application of the ideas of neurodiversity to their condition. Such an approach would not require uniform opinion (which never exists) or even as much of a consensus as is found in autistic community contexts. But it should insist on some critical mass of internal support prior to demanding from the outside the application of neurodiversity ideals.

This too may be a further argument against the descriptive use of the term neurodiversity – as the use of it descriptively to apply to a community that rejects the term’s ideological implications may both prompt confusion and justifiable objection that the broadest possible application of the term interferes with the self-determination of other disability communities.

Operationalizing Neurodiversity: What Are the Practical Stakes?

Whatever its definition and scope, the most important practical question regarding neurodiversity is what it means on the ground. This special issue includes a number of important explorations of this concept. In documenting the #TakeTheMaskOff social media campaign,

Radulski (2022) highlights the tremendous day-to-day stakes autistic people face as a minority living in a world that is often hostile to autistic ways of being, forcing onto autistic persons passing demands akin to those experienced by racial and ethnic minorities and other oppressed peoples. Zajic and Brown (2022) provide an interesting exploration of the implications of neurodiversity ideas on the teaching of writing, exploring what neurodiversity might mean for the teaching of writing and research on the development of autistic writing skills. Botha and Gillespie-Lynch (2022) explore the intersection of autism and other disability communities to which the ideas of neurodiversity have been applied with other forms of marginalized identity. In doing so, they draw on a rich literature on the intersectional impacts of marginalization to better understand autistic identity development and community building, key building blocks for neurodiversity movement activism.

Dwyer (2022) provides a useful theoretical discussion of various approaches neurodiversity could take in operationalizing its ideology for practical service-provision purposes. Ultimately, he argues for an interactionist approach to neurodiversity, which recognizes that challenges emerge from the combination of impairment and environment. (Although he contrasts this with the British “strong” social model of disability, we note that this approach is consistent with the colloquial use of the social model in the USA and how it was understood by many early autistic activists who contributed to the development of neurodiversity ideas.) In the interactionist approach advocated by Dwyer, interventions could target either modifying society or modifying individual traits (or both), but should do so based on which ultimately enhances quality of life rather than based on what is deemed to “cause” an underlying challenge. There is much merit to this approach, which seems to have as a necessary implication an abandonment of the tendency – still so common in traditional autism service-provision – to assume that all autistic traits that diverge from the norm should automatically be suppressed (see Pellicano & den Houting, 2022, for a discussion).

Many debates over the implications of neurodiversity focus on which populations it should be applied to. Particularly in the context of autism, this has often focused on the appropriateness of applying neurodiversity ideas (in particular the rejection of cure and prevention) to autistic persons with severe impairments in communication and cognition. For example, Baron-Cohen (2019) argues for “taking a fine-grained look at the heterogeneity within autism” with the goal of splitting the autism spectrum

孤独谱系群体看起来和行为正常的父母与提供者所使用（参见 Fein 等人, 2013）。与自闭症行为主义方法相关, 神经多样性活动家长长期以来将“康复”孤独谱系群体的愿望视为一种虐待性干预形式的工具（孤独谱系自我倡导网络, 2013; Ne’eman, 2021; Padawar, 2014）。事实上, 孤独谱系活动者积极游说, 反对在DSM-5的孤独谱系定义中包含“康复标准”（Kapp & Ne’eman, 2020）。

在追求最大包容性的过程中, 神经多样性运动者可能无意中实践一种意识形态帝国主义: 坚持将特定的批判和世界观引入那些已有自身、且不相容的意识形态承诺的社群。当然, 也有许多患有精神疾病的人士确实试图将神经多样性应用于自身状况（Graby, 2015; Hart, 2020）。这种意见分歧存在于每个社群中——如果能够解决, 最好通过该社群边界内的内部辩论和争论来实现, 而非由善意的盟友从外部强加一种意识形态。因此, 我们建议在考虑Dwyer关于神经多样性边界的讨论中所阐述的伦理因素之外, 还应考量政治因素: 神经多样性运动应寻求在那些残障社群中变得相关, 这些社群内部存在足够多的支持者, 愿意将神经多样性的理念应用于其自身状况。这种方法不要求统一的意见（这从未存在过）, 甚至不需要达到孤独谱系社群背景中所见的那种共识程度。但它应坚持在从外部要求应用神经多样性理念之前, 社群内部需具备一定的关键性支持基础。

这也可能成为反对使用神经多样性一词进行描述性应用的另一个论据——将其描述性地应用于一个拒绝该术语意识形态内涵的社群, 既可能引发混淆, 也可能招致合理的反对, 即该术语最广泛的应用会干涉其他残障社群的自我决定。

神经多样性的操作化: 实际利害关系是什么?

无论其定义和范围如何, 关于神经多样性最重要的实践问题在于其现实意义。本期特刊收录了若干关于这一概念的重要探讨。在记录#TakeTheMaskOff社交媒体运动时,

Radulski (2022) 强调了孤独谱系群体作为少数群体, 生活在常对孤独谱系存在方式怀有敌意的世界中所面临的巨大日常风险, 社会强加给孤独谱系群体的伪装要求, 类似于种族和族裔少数群体及其他受压迫人群所经历的状况。Zajic与Brown (2022) 对神经多样性理念在写作教学中的影响进行了有趣的探讨, 研究了神经多样性可能对写作教学以及孤独谱系写作技能发展的研究意味着什么。Botha与Gillespie-Lynch (2022) 探讨了孤独谱系与其他残障社群的交集, 神经多样性的理念已与其它形式的边缘化身份认同一起应用于这些社群。在此过程中, 他们借鉴了关于边缘化交叉影响的丰富文献, 以更好地理解孤独谱系身份发展和社群建设——这些是神经多样性运动行动主义的关键基石。

Dwyer（2022年）就神经多样性如何将其理念操作化以用于实际服务提供目的的各种方法, 提供了有益的理论探讨。最终, 他主张一种互动主义的神经多样性方法, 该方法承认挑战源自于损伤与环境的结合。（尽管他将此与英国“强”社会残障模型进行对比, 但我们注意到, 这种方法与美国社会模型的通俗用法以及许多早期孤独谱系活动者在推动神经多样性理念发展时对其的理解是一致的。）在Dwyer倡导的互动主义方法中, 干预措施可以针对改变社会或改变个人特质（或两者兼而有之）, 但选择依据应是什么最终能提升生活质量, 而非基于什么被认定为“导致”了根本性挑战。这种方法有很多优点, 其一个必然的推论似乎是: 必须摒弃那种在传统孤独谱系服务提供中仍非常普遍的倾向, 即认为所有偏离常态的孤独谱系特质都应自动被压制（相关讨论参见Pellicano & den Houting, 2022年）。

许多关于神经多样性含义的争论, 都聚焦于它应适用于哪些人群。特别是在孤独谱系的语境下, 争论常常集中在将神经多样性理念（尤其是拒绝治愈和预防）应用于那些在沟通和认知方面有重度障碍的孤独谱系群体是否合适。例如, Baron-Cohen（2019）主张“对孤独谱系内部的异质性进行细致入微的审视”, 目的是将孤独谱系

Downloaded from <http://karger.com/development/article-pdf/66/2/149/3750903/000524277.pdf> by guest on 08 January 2026

into those components to which a neurodiversity approach should be applied and those for which the traditional medical model may be more appropriate. Similarly, some critics of the neurodiversity movement have recently called for the creation of a separate “profound” or “severe autism” diagnostic category in which to place those with the most severe impairments, a position endorsed often out of a desire to separate such individuals from the service-provision changes argued for by neurodiversity and disability rights activists (National Council on Severe Autism, 2021). Others, including both autistic people and parents of autistic persons with severe impairments, have criticized such an approach, arguing that doing so creates an artificial division and segregates higher-support need autistic people from innovations and rights that they too should have access to (Autistic Self Advocacy Network, 2021; Rosa, 2021).

We agree with this latter perspective. There is no scientific basis for segmenting the autism spectrum in the way that proponents of a separate “severe” autism label suggest. Doing so poses grave risks, potentially segregating those subject to such a severe label from the rights and efforts at community integration won in the broader disability context. Nonetheless, we do believe that it is important for neurodiversity proponents to make the case explicitly that their ideas have relevance to those with the most severe impairment. Contrary to the movement’s critics, many, if not all, neurodiversity advocacy organizations are actively concerned with severe disability, investing considerable resources into advocating for more resources for long-term services and supports, augmentative and alternative communication, and other needs that are most acute among autistic people with the most severe impairments (Ne’eman & Bascom, 2020). Research on the views of those who support neurodiversity documents that most do not object to measures designed to improve adaptive skills as opposed to suppressing autistic traits (Kapp et al., 2013).

We suggest a further contribution to help make the case for neurodiversity’s broad applicability, accomplished via a simple and long overdue paradigm shift. Rather than debate which populations neurodiversity should be applied to, we argue that neurodiversity is best understood as applying to individual *traits* – what in the medical context might be referred to as symptoms – rather than to whole *people or populations*. Efforts to suppress hand flapping and other forms of “stimming” or to demand eye contact are unacceptable regardless of how severely impaired a person may be in cognition or communication. This is because they are not intrinsically harm-

ful. In contrast, self-injury, violence, or lack of a functional communication system are appropriate targets of service-provider intervention because they represent intrinsic harms to the person who experiences them or others. In such instances, the harms are not the result of stigma but would emerge regardless of the prevailing social norms. Such actions can be appropriate targets of intervention.

Such an approach recognizes that, rather than splitting autistic people and other disability communities into groups subject to the neurodiversity model and groups subject to the traditional medical model, both models might conceivably have application in the same person. By taking a trait-oriented approach to operationalizing neurodiversity, it is possible to address intrinsically harmful disability-related traits, such as self-injury, lack of communication, or anorexia, while also rejecting and fighting against the clinical passing demands embedded within so much of autism service-provision and research practice (Ne’eman, 2021). Such an approach is consistent with Dwyer’s interactionist approach and the vast majority of high-level neurodiversity activism in practice. It also represents a useful approach through which to combat the harms created by demands from clinicians, family members, and the broader society that autistic people attempt to pass as non-autistic. As Botha and Gillespie-Lynch (2022) discuss in their exploration of the applicability of the minority stress model to autism and neurological disability, there is a longstanding literature showing the harms such passing demands cause in the context of other forms of marginalized identity that has considerable relevance.

This innovation also has the potential to open up doors for expanding neurodiversity’s critique of service-provision practices beyond the realm of mental disability, as many other disability categories experience harm from clinical passing demands imposed by providers. Although much work is needed to further articulate and operationalize these ideas, we have hope that in doing so neurodiversity activists can develop a set of conceptual and practical tools that will yield benefit across the disability community. The possibility exists that the neurodiversity critique – though now distinct – may eventually serve its purpose and be simply reabsorbed into the larger disability rights movement it is now layered on top of. Such a long-term outcome for neurodiversity would set the stage for a common front to transform research and service-provision in all areas of disability, not just those relating to the brain.

拆分为两部分：一部分适用于神经多样性方法，另一部分则可能更适合传统的医学模型。同样地，神经多样性运动的一些批评者最近呼吁创建一个独立的“重度”或“重度孤独谱系”诊断类别，用于安置那些障碍最严重的个体；这一立场常出于一种愿望，即让这些个体免受神经多样性和残障权利活动者所倡导的服务供给变革的影响（National Council on Severe Autism, 2021）。包括孤独谱系群体自身以及有重度障碍的孤独谱系人士的家长在内的其他人则批评了这种做法，认为这样做制造了人为的分裂，并将高支持需求的孤独谱系群体隔离在创新和权利之外，而这些创新和权利本应是他们同样有权享有的（孤独谱系自我倡导网络，2021；Rosa, 2021）。

我们赞同后一种观点。将孤独谱系按照主张单独“重度”孤独谱系标签的人士所建议的方式进行划分，是缺乏科学依据的。这样做会带来严重的风险，可能使被贴上此类重度标签的人与在更广泛的残障背景下赢得的权利及社区融合努力相隔离。尽管如此，我们确实认为，神经多样性的支持者明确阐述其理念对功能受损最严重的群体同样具有相关性，这一点至关重要。与批评该运动的人士相反，许多（即使不是全部）神经多样性倡导组织都积极关注重度残障问题，投入大量资源倡导为长期服务与支持、扩大与替代性沟通以及其他在功能受损最严重的孤独谱系群体中最为迫切的需求争取更多资源（Ne’eman & Bascom, 2020）。关于神经多样性支持者观点的研究表明，他们大多并不反对旨在提高适应技能的措施，这与压制孤独谱系特质的行为截然不同（Kapp 等, 2013）。

我们提出一个进一步的贡献，以帮助论证神经多样性的广泛适用性，这通过一个简单且早该实现的范式转变来完成。我们主张，与其争论神经多样性应适用于哪些人群，不如将其理解为适用于个体的特质——在医学语境中可能被称为症状——而非整个人或人群。无论一个人在认知或沟通方面受损多么严重，试图抑制手部拍打和其他形式的“刺激行为”或要求眼神接触都是不可接受的。这是因为它们本质上并非有害——

相反，自伤、暴力或缺乏功能性沟通系统，则是服务提供者干预的适当目标，因为它们代表着对经历者本人或他人的内在伤害。在此类情况下，伤害并非源于污名，而是无论主流社会规范如何都会出现。这些行为可以成为干预的适当目标。

这种方法认识到，与其将孤独谱系群体和其他残障社群划分为受神经多样性模型影响的群体和受传统医学模型影响的群体，不如承认这两种模型都可能适用于同一个人。通过采取以特质为导向的方法来操作化神经多样性，就有可能解决本质上具有伤害性的、与残障相关的特质，例如自伤、缺乏沟通或神经性厌食症，同时也拒绝并反抗根植于大量孤独谱系服务提供和研究实践中的临床伪装要求（Ne’eman, 2021）。这种方法与 Dwyer 互动主义方法以及实践中绝大多数高层次的神经多样性行动主义是一致的。它也代表了一种有用的方法，可以用来对抗由临床医生、家庭成员和更广泛社会的要求所造成的伤害，这些要求迫使孤独谱系群体试图伪装成非孤独谱系者。正如 Botha 和 Gillespie-Lynch（2022）在他们探讨少数群体压力模型对孤独谱系和神经性残障的适用性时所讨论的，已有大量长期文献表明，这类伪装要求在其他形式的边缘化身份背景下所造成的伤害，具有相当大的相关性。

这项创新也具备潜力，能将神经多样性对服务提供实践的批判拓展至精神残障领域之外，因为许多其他残障类别同样遭受着服务提供者强加的临床伪装要求所带来的伤害。尽管需要大量工作来进一步阐明并实践这些想法，但我们抱有希望：通过努力，神经多样性活动家能够开发出一套概念性与实践性的工具，为整个残障社群带来益处。存在这样一种可能性：神经多样性的批判——尽管目前是独立的——或许最终会完成其使命，并简单地被重新吸纳进它所依附的、更宏大的残障权利运动中。神经多样性的这一长远结局，将为建立一个共同阵线奠定基础，以变革所有残障领域（而不仅仅是与大脑相关的领域）的研究和服务提供。

Acknowledgements The authors are grateful to Marc Stears and Amanda Vivian for discussion of the ideas presented in this commentary.	Funding Sources E.P. was supported by an Australian Research Council Future Fellowship (FT190100077). The views expressed are the views of the authors alone and do not necessarily represent the views of their organizations or funding sources. A.N was supported by the National Institute of Mental Health of the National Institutes of Health under Award Number T32MH019733. The content is solely the responsibility of the authors and does not necessarily represent the official views of the National Institutes of Health.		致谢 作者感谢Marc Stears和Amanda Vivian就本文评论中所提观点进行的讨论。	
Statement of Ethics No ethical approval was required for the preparation of this manuscript, as no human or animal subjects were used.	伦理声明 本文稿的撰写无需伦理批准，因其未使用任何人类或动物受试者。		资金来源 E.P. 获得了澳大利亚研究委员会未来研究员基金（FT190100077）的支持。本文观点仅代表作者个人，不一定代表其所属机构或资助方的观点。A.N. 获得了美国国立卫生研究院下属国家心理健康研究所的资助，资助编号为T32MH019733。文章内容仅由作者负责，不一定代表美国国立卫生研究院的官方观点。	
Conflict of Interest Statement The authors have no conflicts of interest of which they are aware.	作者贡献 A.N. 与 E.P. 讨论了本文提出的观点；A.N. 撰写了稿件初稿；E.P. 审阅并编辑了稿件；两位作者均在提交前批准了稿件的最终版本。			
References Asasumasu, K. (2016). <i>PSA from the actual coiner of “neurodivergent”</i>. Tumblr.https://sherlocks-flataffect.tumblr.com/post/121295972384/psa-from-the-actual-coiner-of-neurodivergent Asch, A., & Barlevy, D. (2012). <i>Disability and genetics: A disability critique of pre-natal testing and pre-implantation genetic diagnosis (PGD)</i>. eLS. Autistic Self Advocacy Network. (2013, January 23). <i>ASAN statement on Fein study on autism and “recovery”</i>. https://autisticadvocacy.org/2013/01/asan-statement-on-fein-study-on-autism-and-recovery/#_edn1 Autistic Self Advocacy Network. (2021, December 9). <i>Functioning labels harm autistic people</i>. https://autisticadvocacy.org/2021/12/functioning-labels-harm-autistic-people/ Bailin, A. (2019, June 6). <i>Clearing up some misconceptions about neurodiversity</i>. Scientific American. https://blogs.scientificamerican.com/observations/clearing-up-some-misconceptions-about-neurodiversity/ Baron-Cohen, S. (2019, April 30). <i>The concept of neurodiversity is dividing the autism community</i>. Scientific American. https://blogs.scientificamerican.com/observations/the-concept-of-neurodiversity-is-dividing-the-autism-community/ Bertilsdotter Rosqvist, H., Chown, N., & Stenning, A. (Eds.). (2020). <i>Neurodiversity studies: A new critical paradigm</i>. Routledge. Botha, M., & Gillespie-Lynch, K. (2022). Come as you are: Examining autistic identity development and the neurodiversity movement through an intersectional lens. <i>Human Development</i>, 66(2). Buckle K. L. (2020). Autscope. In S. Kapp (Ed.), <i>Autistic community and the neurodiversity movement</i> (pp. 109–22). Palgrave Macmillan.	Chapman, R. (2020). Defining neurodiversity for research and practice. In H. Bertilsdotter Rosqvist, N. Chown & A. Stenning (Eds.), <i>Neurodiversity studies: A new critical paradigm</i> (pp. 218–20). Routledge. Chapman, R. (2021, August 18). Negotiating the neurodiversity concept: Towards epistemic justice in conceptualising health. <i>Psychology Today</i>. https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/neurodiverse-age/202108/negotiating-the-neurodiversity-concept Dekker, M. (1999). On our own terms: Emerging autistic culture. Autism99 Online Conference. http://www.autscope.org/2015/programme/handouts/Autistic-Culture-07-Oct-1999.pdf den Houting, J. (2019). Neurodiversity: An insider’s perspective. <i>Autism</i>, 23, 271–273. Durbin-Westby, P. C. (2012, April 1).From the pro-neurodiversity trenches. https://autisticadvocacy.org/2012/04/from-the-pro-neurodiversity-trenches/ Dwyer,P.(2022).The neurodiversityapproach(es): What are they and what do they mean for researchers? <i>Human Development</i>, 66(2). Ernst & Young (n.d.). Neurodiversity-powered transformation. https://www.ey.com/en_us/innovation/neurodiversity-powered-transformation Fein, D, Barton, M, Eigsti, IM, Kelley, E, Naigles, L, Schultz, RT, Stevens M, Helt M, Orinstein A, Rosenthal M, Troyb E, & Tyson K. (2013). Optimal outcome in individuals with a history of autism. <i>Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry</i>, 54, 195–205. Gillespie-Lynch, K., Dwyer, P., Constantino, C., Kapp, S. K., Hotez, E., Riccio, A., DeNigris, D., Kofner, B., & Endlich, E. (2020). Can we broaden the neurodiversity movement without weakening it? Participatory approaches as a framework for cross-disability alliance building. In A. C. Carey, J. M. Ostrove & T. Fannon (Eds.), <i>Disability alliances and allies: Opportunities and challenges</i>. Emerald.	Graby, S. (2015). Neurodiversity: Bridging the gap between the disabled people’s movement and the mental health system survivors’ movement. In J. Anderson, B. Sapey & H. Spandler (Eds.), <i>Madness, distress and the politics of disablement</i> (pp. 231–244). Policy Press. Grandin, T., & Scariano, M. M. (1986). <i>Emergence: Labeled autistic</i>. Arena Press. Hart, A. (2020). A new alliance? The hearing voices movement and neurodiversity. In H. Bertilsdotter Rosqvist, N. Chown & A. Stenning (Eds.), <i>Neurodiversity studies: A new critical paradigm</i> (pp. 221–225). Routledge. Heilker, P., & Yergeau, M. (2011). Autism and rhetoric. <i>College English</i>, 73, 485–497. Jiujias, M., Kelley, E., & Hall, L. (2017). Restricted, repetitive behaviors in autism spectrum disorder and obsessive-compulsive disorder: A comparative review. <i>Child Psychiatry & Human Development</i>, 48, 944–959. Kapp, S. K., Gillespie-Lynch, K., Sherman, L. E., & Hutman, T. (2013). Deficit, difference, or both? Autism and neurodiversity. <i>Developmental Psychology</i>, 49, 59–71. Kapp, S. K., & Ne’eman, A. (2020). Lobbying Autism’s Diagnostic Revision in the DSM-5. In S. Kapp (Ed.), <i>Autistic community and the neurodiversity movement</i> (pp. 167–94). Palgrave Macmillan. King, B. H. (2019). Fluoxetine and repetitive behaviors in children and adolescents with autism spectrum disorder. <i>Journal of the American Medical Association</i>, 322(16), 1557–1558. Kras, J. F. (2010). The “ransom notes” affair: When the neurodiversity movement came of age. <i>Disability Studies Quarterly</i>, 30. https://dsq-sds.org/article/%C2%A0view/1065/1254 Leadbitter, K., Buckle, K. L., Ellis, C., & Dekker, M. (2021). Autistic self-advocacy and the neurodiversity movement: Implications for autism early intervention research and practice. <i>Frontiers in Psychology</i>, 12, 635690.	Asasumasu, K. (2016). <i>PSA from the actual coiner of “neurodivergent”</i>. Tumblr.https://sherlocks-flataffect.tumblr.com/post/121295972384/psa-from-the-actual-coiner-of-neurodivergent Asch, A., & Barlevy, D. (2012). <i>Disability and genetics: A disability critique of pre-natal testing and pre-implantation genetic diagnosis (PGD)</i>. eLS. Autistic Self Advocacy Network. (2013, January 23). <i>ASAN statement on Fein study on autism and “recovery”</i>. https://autisticadvocacy.org/2013/01/asan-statement-on-fein-study-on-autism-and-recovery/#_edn1 Autistic Self Advocacy Network. (2021, December 9). <i>Functioning labels harm autistic people</i>. https://autisticadvocacy.org/2021/12/functioning-labels-harm-autistic-people/ Bailin, A. (2019, June 6). <i>Clearing up some misconceptions about neurodiversity</i>. Scientific American. https://blogs.scientificamerican.com/observations/clearing-up-some-misconceptions-about-neurodiversity/ Baron-Cohen, S. (2019, April 30). <i>The concept of neurodiversity is dividing the autism community</i>. Scientific American. https://blogs.scientificamerican.com/observations/the-concept-of-neurodiversity-is-dividing-the-autism-community/ Bertilsdotter Rosqvist, H., Chown, N., & Stenning, A. (Eds.). (2020). <i>Neurodiversity studies: A new critical paradigm</i>. Routledge. Botha, M., & Gillespie-Lynch, K. (2022). Come as you are: Examining autistic identity development and the neurodiversity movement through an intersectional lens. <i>Human Development</i>, 66(2). Buckle K. L. (2020). Autscope. In S. Kapp (Ed.), <i>Autistic community and the neurodiversity movement</i> (pp. 109–22). Palgrave Macmillan.	Graby, S. (2015). Neurodiversity: Bridging the gap between the disabled people’s movement and the mental health system survivors’ movement. In J. Anderson, B. Sapey & H. Spandler (Eds.), <i>Madness, distress and the politics of disablement</i> (pp. 231–244). Policy Press. Grandin, T., & Scariano, M. M. (1986). <i>Emergence: Labeled autistic</i>. Arena Press. Hart, A. (2020). A new alliance? The hearing voices movement and neurodiversity. In H. Bertilsdotter Rosqvist, N. Chown & A. Stenning (Eds.), <i>Neurodiversity studies: A new critical paradigm</i> (pp. 221–225). Routledge. Heilker, P., & Yergeau, M. (2011). Autism and rhetoric. <i>College English</i>, 73, 485–497. Jiujias, M., Kelley, E., & Hall, L. (2017). Restricted, repetitive behaviors in autism spectrum disorder and obsessive-compulsive disorder: A comparative review. <i>Child Psychiatry & Human Development</i>, 48, 944–959. Kapp, S. K., Gillespie-Lynch, K., Sherman, L. E., & Hutman, T. (2013). Deficit, difference, or both? Autism and neurodiversity. <i>Developmental Psychology</i>, 49, 59–71. Kapp, S. K., & Ne’eman, A. (2020). Lobbying Autism’s Diagnostic Revision in the DSM-5. In S. Kapp (Ed.), <i>Autistic community and the neurodiversity movement</i> (pp. 167–94). Palgrave Macmillan. King, B. H. (2019). Fluoxetine and repetitive behaviors in children and adolescents with autism spectrum disorder. <i>Journal of the American Medical Association</i>, 322(16), 1557–1558. Kras, J. F. (2010). The “ransom notes” affair: When the neurodiversity movement came of age. <i>Disability Studies Quarterly</i>, 30. https://dsq-sds.org/article/%C2%A0view/1065/1254 Leadbitter, K., Buckle, K. L., Ellis, C., & Dekker, M. (2021). Autistic self-advocacy and the neurodiversity movement: Implications for autism early intervention research and practice. <i>Frontiers in Psychology</i>, 12, 635690.

Microsoft (n.d.). Microsoft neurodiversity hiring program & FAQ. <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/diversity/inside-microsoft/cross-disability/neurodiversityhiring>

Morrison, L. J. (2013). *Talking back to psychiatry: The psychiatric consumer/survivor/ex-patient movement*. Routledge.

National Council on Severe Autism (2021). *Calls for categorical recognition of severe autism in the DSM*. <https://www.ncsautism.org/blog/dsmrevision>

Ne’eman, A. (2021). When disability is defined by behavior, outcome measures should not promote ‘passing’. *AMA Journal of Ethics*, 23, E569–E575.

Ne’eman, A., Albrecht, K., & Kapp, S. K. (2020). Obsessive-compulsive behaviors in autism. *Journal of the American Medical Association*, 323, 790.

Ne’eman, A., & Bascom, J. (2020). Autistic self-advocacy in the developmental disability movement. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 20, 25–27.

Padawar, R. (2014). *The kids who beat autism*. The New York Times. <https://www.nytimes.com/2014/08/03/magazine/the-kids-who-beat-autism.html>

Pellicano, E., & den Houting, J. (2022). Annual research review: Shifting from “normal science” to neurodiversity in autism science. *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 63(4), 381–396.

Pripas-Kapit, S. (2020). Historicizing Jim Sinclair’s “don’t mourn for us”: A cultural and intellectual history of neurodiversity’s first manifesto. In S. K. Kapp (Ed.), *Autistic community and the neurodiversity movement: Stories from the frontline* (pp. 23–39). Palgrave Macmillan.

Radulski, B. M. (2022). Conceptualising autistic masking, camouflaging, and neurotypical privilege: Towards a minority group model of neurodiversity. *Human Development*, 66(2).

Robertson, S. M. (2010). Neurodiversity, quality of life, and autistic adults: Shifting research and professional focuses onto real-life challenges. *Disability Studies Quarterly*, 30. <http://dsq-sds.org/article/view/1069/1234>

Rosa, S. (2021, December 8). Creating a ‘profound autism’ category is segregation, not progress. Thinking person’s guide to autism. <http://www.thinkingautismguide.com/2021/12/creating-profound-autism-category-is.html>

Rottier, H., & Gernsbacher, M. A. (2020). Autistic adult and non-autistic parent advocates: Bridging the divide. In A. Carey, J. Ostrove & T. Fannon (Eds.), *Disability alliances and allies* (pp. 155–66). Emerald.

Sinclair, J. (1993). Don’t mourn for us.http://www.autreat.com/dont_mourn.html

Sinclair, J. (2005, January). Autism network international: The development of a community and its culture. http://www.autreat.com/History_of_ANI.html

Sinclair, J. (2010). Cultural commentary: Being autistic together. *Disability Studies Quarterly*. 30.<https://dsq-sds.org/article/view/1075/1248>

Solvang, P. K., & Haualand, H. (2014). Accessibility and diversity: Deaf space in action. *Scandinavian Journal of Disability Research*, 16(1), 1–13.

Thomas, T. (2021, April 2). Pilot increases neurodiversity in government. Performance.gov. <https://www.performance.gov/blog/mitre-neurodiversity-pilot/>

Walker, N. (2014). Neurodiversity: Some basic terms & definitions. <https://neuroqueer.com/neurodiversity-terms-and-definitions/>

Zajic, M. C., & Brown, H. M. (2022). Measuring autistic writing skills: Combining perspectives from neurodiversity advocates, autism researchers, and writing theories. *Human Development*, 66(2).

Microsoft (n.d.). Microsoft neurodiversity hiring program & FAQ. <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/diversity/inside-microsoft/cross-disability/neurodiversityhiring>

Morrison, L. J. (2013). *Talking back to psychiatry: The psychiatric consumer/survivor/ex-patient movement*. Routledge.

National Council on Severe Autism (2021). *Calls for categorical recognition of severe autism in the DSM*. <https://www.ncsautism.org/blog/dsmrevision>

Ne’eman, A. (2021). When disability is defined by behavior, outcome measures should not promote ‘passing’. *AMA Journal of Ethics*, 23, E569–E575.

Ne’eman, A., Albrecht, K., & Kapp, S. K. (2020). Obsessive-compulsive behaviors in autism. *Journal of the American Medical Association*, 323, 790.

Ne’eman, A., & Bascom, J. (2020). Autistic self-advocacy in the developmental disability movement. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 20, 25–27.

Padawar, R. (2014). *The kids who beat autism*. The New York Times. <https://www.nytimes.com/2014/08/03/magazine/the-kids-who-beat-autism.html>

Pellicano, E., & den Houting, J. (2022). Annual research review: Shifting from “normal science” to neurodiversity in autism science. *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 63(4), 381–396.

Pripas-Kapit, S. (2020). Historicizing Jim Sinclair’s “don’t mourn for us”: A cultural and intellectual history of neurodiversity’s first manifesto. In S. K. Kapp (Ed.), *Autistic community and the neurodiversity movement: Stories from the frontline* (pp. 23–39). Palgrave Macmillan.

Radulski, B. M. (2022). Conceptualising autistic masking, camouflaging, and neurotypical privilege: Towards a minority group model of neurodiversity. *Human Development*, 66(2).

Robertson, S. M. (2010). Neurodiversity, quality of life, and autistic adults: Shifting research and professional focuses onto real-life challenges. *Disability Studies Quarterly*, 30. <http://dsq-sds.org/article/view/1069/1234>

Rosa, S. (2021, December 8). Creating a ‘profound autism’ category is segregation, not progress. Thinking person’s guide to autism. <http://www.thinkingautismguide.com/2021/12/creating-profound-autism-category-is.html>

Rottier, H., & Gernsbacher, M. A. (2020). Autistic adult and non-autistic parent advocates: Bridging the divide. In A. Carey, J. Ostrove & T. Fannon (Eds.), *Disability alliances and allies* (pp. 155–66). Emerald.

Sinclair, J. (1993). Don’t mourn for us.http://www.autreat.com/dont_mourn.html

Sinclair, J. (2005, January). Autism network international: The development of a community and its culture. http://www.autreat.com/History_of_ANI.html

Sinclair, J. (2010). Cultural commentary: Being autistic together. *Disability Studies Quarterly*. 30.<https://dsq-sds.org/article/view/1075/1248>

Solvang, P. K., & Haualand, H. (2014). Accessibility and diversity: Deaf space in action. *Scandinavian Journal of Disability Research*, 16(1), 1–13.

Thomas, T. (2021, April 2). Pilot increases neurodiversity in government. Performance.gov. <https://www.performance.gov/blog/mitre-neurodiversity-pilot/>

Walker, N. (2014). Neurodiversity: Some basic terms & definitions. <https://neuroqueer.com/neurodiversity-terms-and-definitions/>

Zajic, M. C., & Brown, H. M. (2022). Measuring autistic writing skills: Combining perspectives from neurodiversity advocates, autism researchers, and writing theories. *Human Development*, 66(2).

Downloaded from <http://karger.com/nd/article-pdf/66/2/149/3750903/000524277.pdf> by guest on 08 January 2026